SC, ST and OBC faculty in India

A data study from AISHE 2019-20 to 2023-24 · iGEM IISER Kolkata 2026 · Inclusivity ·

Background

Reserved posts exist so that faculty include people from SC, ST and OBC communities. Faculty are who students see in class and the lab. National figures can show where, in the path from student to teacher, the shares fall, and whether one institute's numbers are unusual.

Aims

To describe, from the Ministry's national survey of higher education, how many teachers are from SC, ST and OBC communities, how this compares with students at each level and by type of institution and state, and where IISER Kolkata sits among them.

Results

- In 2023-24 AISHE counts 1.73 million teachers in India: 9.6% SC, 2.8% ST and 32.6% OBC (45.1% together). All three shares have risen since 2019-20; the combined share moved from 43.5% to 45.1%.
- Faculty shares sit well below undergraduate shares (SC 15.6%, ST 6.3%) and close to PhD shares (10.0% and 4.1%). Nationally, most of the loss comes before the faculty stage, between undergraduate level and the PhD [2].
- Institutes of National Importance (INIs), the AISHE category that includes the IISERs, are the exception. Their faculty are 26.1% from these groups against 46.3% of their students. Central universities show no such gap (35.5% against 35.6%).
- New appointments are more diverse than the existing stock. At INIs, 40.6% of the net increase in faculty since 2019-20 came from these groups, against 21.0% of the 2019-20 stock. But students' share rose too, so the gap is still about 20 points.
- IISER Kolkata, at 16.0% (institute figures), is below the INI average on each group: SC 6.1% against 8.3%, ST 0.8% against 2.3%, OBC 9.2% against 15.6%.
- Across states, SC faculty share rises only 0.43 points for each point of SC student share (95% interval 0.31 to 0.57), compared with 0.84 for OBC. SC women are 39.7% of SC faculty, against 44.9% women among all faculty.

Introduction

Our student study found that the share of SC, ST and OBC students at the IISERs is close to the reserved seat share. Our inquiry into faculty at IISER Kolkata found a much lower share (16.0% of 131, from the institute). That raises the question this study addresses: is the gap between students and faculty a local feature, or does it appear across Indian higher education, and at which stage does it open?

The national survey of higher education (AISHE) collects the number of teachers by social group, gender, state and type of university each year. It does not name institutes, and it cannot say why any pattern exists. We use it to place one institute's numbers in context, not to explain them.

Our dataset

We used the Final Reports of AISHE for 2019-20, 2021-22, 2022-23 and 2023-24 (Excel versions) [1]. The 2020-21 report was not among the files. The tables used are: teachers by state, social group and gender (Table 21); teachers by social group and type of university, in university teaching departments (Table 30); enrolment by social group and type of university (Table 27) and by state (Table 14); and enrolment by programme (Table 11), for the PhD row. We read them into one dataset and checked that states add up to the all-India row, and types add up to the total, in every year.

"Teachers" are all teaching staff reported by institutions, in universities, colleges and standalone institutions, without separating regular from other appointments. SC, ST and OBC are reported as separate groups, so for "together" we add them. The group "All" also contains people who did not report a category.

Reference lines. Central institutions reserve 15% for SC, 7.5% for ST and 27% for OBC [3]. State institutions follow state rules, including state OBC lists that differ from the central list. So national and state figures are not compared against one legal line. We draw the central figures for orientation only.

Main findings

1. The national trend

In 2023-24, SC teachers were 9.6% of 1.73 million, ST 2.8% and OBC 32.6% (Figure 1). Four years earlier they were 9.0%, 2.4% and 32.1%. The number of SC teachers grew by 24%, ST by 34% and OBC by 17%, against 15% for all teachers. SC and ST remain well below 15% and 7.5%. OBC is above 27%, partly because state lists and rules differ from the central ones. Part of the rise in the counts may come from more institutions reporting; shares are less affected by this than counts, but not immune.

The pace is slow. SC share rose by 0.66 points in four years, about 0.17 a year. At that pace, reaching 15% would take about 32 years. This is arithmetic, not a forecast, since the pace may change.

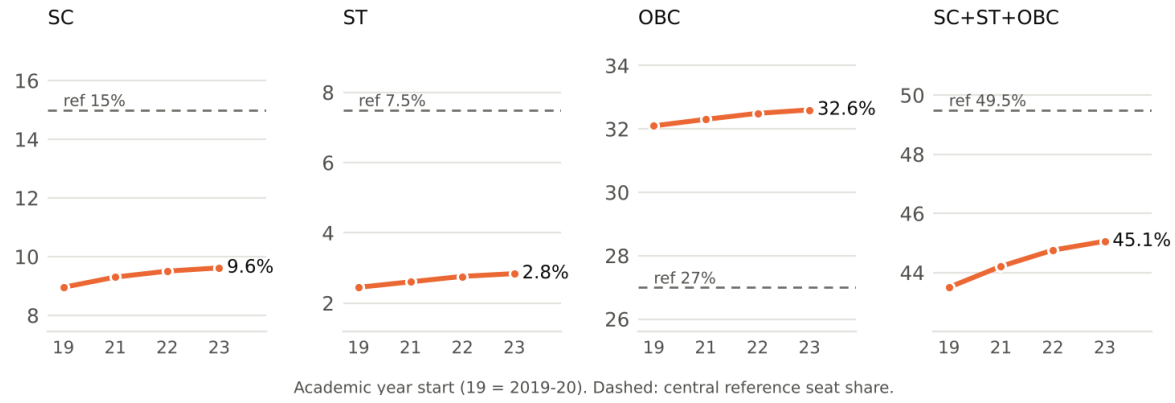


Figure 1: Share of teachers from SC, ST and OBC communities, India. Each panel shows one group; the dashed line is the central reference seat share. The 2020-21 survey was not available. Source: AISHE Table 21.

2. Recruit diversity

Of the net increase of 229 thousand teachers between 2019-20 and 2023-24, 14.0% were SC, 5.4% ST and 35.9% OBC (Figure 2). Each exceeds the group's share of the 2019-20 stock (9.0%, 2.4%, 32.1%). Women are a larger share still: 60.8% of the increase, against 42.5% of the stock. New appointments are therefore more diverse than the stock they join. This is a net figure: it does not show who left, and some of the increase may come from institutions that began reporting.

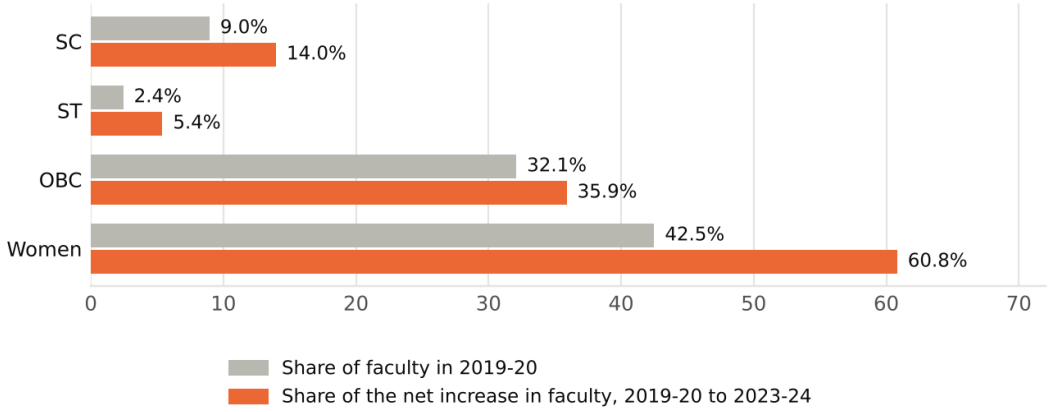


Figure 2: Stock of faculty in 2019-20 against share of the net increase. Net increase is the change in the number of teachers between 2019-20 and 2023-24. Source: AISHE Table 21.

3. From student to teacher

Figure 3 puts the faculty share beside the share among undergraduate, postgraduate and PhD students in 2023-24. For SC, the shares fall from 15.6% (UG) to 10.0% (PhD), and the faculty share (9.6%) is close to the PhD share. ST goes from 6.3% to 4.1%, with faculty lower still at 2.8%. OBC falls from 41.0% to 28.1%, and the faculty share (32.6%) is above the PhD share. Together: UG 62.9%, PG 57.4%, PhD 42.3%, faculty 45.1%.

Read nationally, most of the loss comes between UG and PhD [2], and faculty shares then follow the PhD share. Two cautions apply. Faculty at any time were PhD students years ago, so the comparison is between different generations. And the AISHE PhD count jumped from 227,000 to 335,000 between 2022-23 and 2023-24, so the latest PhD shares may partly reflect reporting changes. ST faculty are the exception: their share is lower than the PhD share, so ST loses more at the last step.

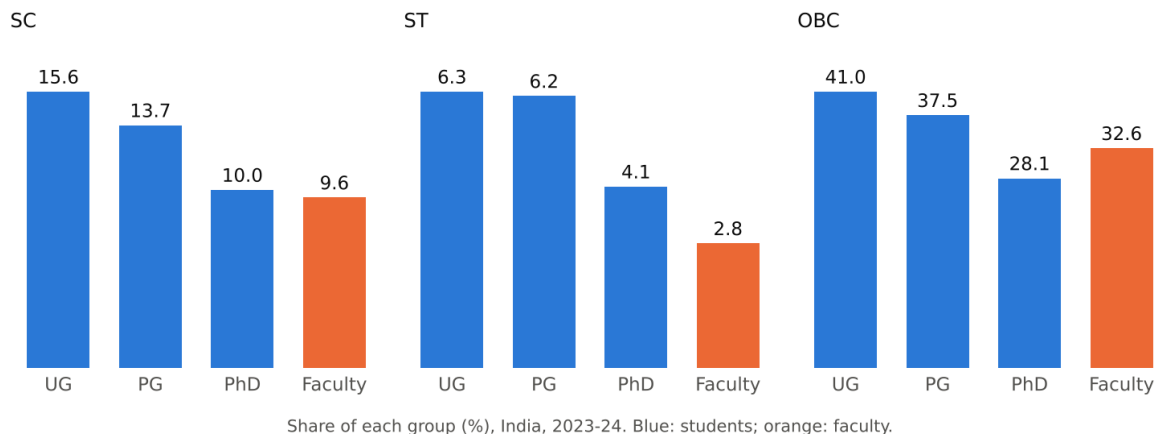


Figure 3: Share of SC, ST and OBC at each stage, India, 2023-24. UG and PG shares are from the team's AISHE study [2]; the PhD share is from Table 11 and the faculty share from Table 21.

4. Type of institution: the INI gap

The national picture hides a large difference by type (Figure 4). In central universities the faculty share matches the student share (35.5% against 35.6%), and ST faculty (6.9%) exceed ST students (4.4%). In Institutes of National Importance, which include the IITs, NITs, IISERs and AIIMS, faculty are 26.1% from these groups and students 46.3%: a ratio of 0.56. For comparison, the ratio is 0.64 in state public universities and 0.62 in state private universities. For INIs the group-wise ratios are SC 0.62, ST 0.35 and OBC 0.59.

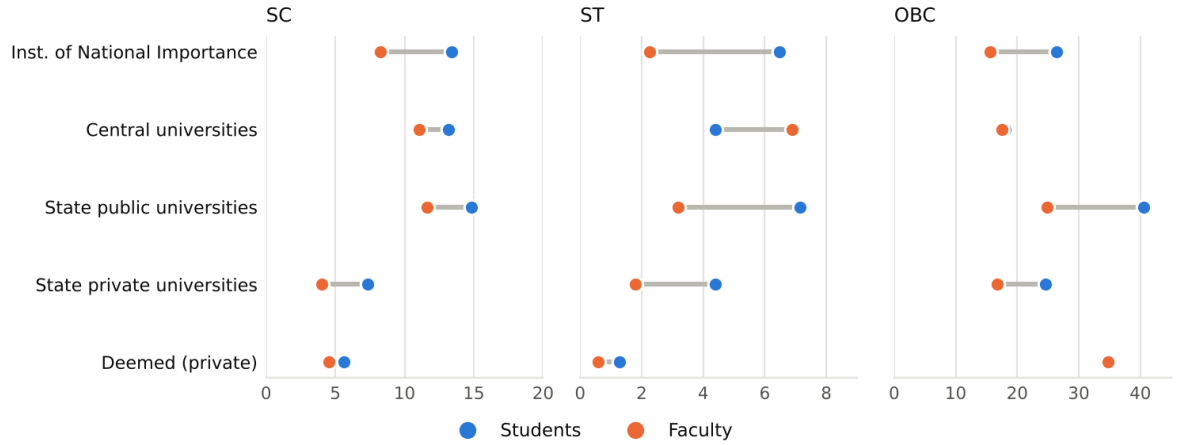


Figure 4: Share of students and faculty by type of university, 2023-24. Blue: students; orange: faculty. A long bar means a large gap. Source: AISHE Tables 27 and 30.

Over time, INI faculty rose from 21.0% to 26.1% (+5.1 points), faster than the national +1.6. But the INI student share also rose, from 41.6% to 46.3%, so the gap hardly changed (20.6 to 20.2 points; Figure 5). Of the net increase in INI faculty, 40.6% came from these groups (SC 12.5%, ST 4.2%, OBC 23.9%), so new appointments are approaching the student share, but the stock is changing slowly.

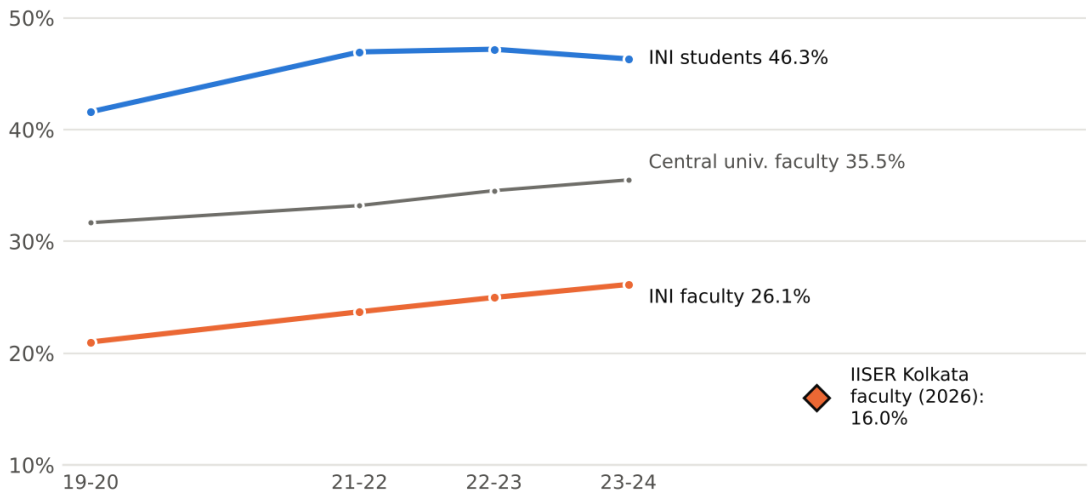


Figure 5: SC+ST+OBC share among INI students and faculty over time. The diamond marks IISER Kolkata's faculty share from the institute (2026), shown for comparison; it is not part of the AISHE series. Source: AISHE Tables 27 and 30.

5. Where IISER Kolkata sits

Placed beside the INI average (Figure 6), IISER Kolkata's faculty shares are lower on each group: SC 6.1% against 8.3%, ST 0.8% against 2.3%, OBC 9.2% against 15.6%, and 16.0% against 26.1% (aggregate). Central universities, at 35.5%, are further ahead. This comparison is rough. The INI category covers many kinds of institutes. AISHE counts all teachers and the institute's figures are for regular faculty, with the director excluded, and they refer to 2026, not 2023-24. A difference of a few points would not mean much, but these gaps are larger than that.

The latest hiring cycle at Kolkata (7 of 7 appointments from reserved categories) points the same way as the INI pattern of new appointments being more diverse than the stock. It is more extreme than the INI average, where about 41% of the net increase since 2019-20 came from these groups, but it is seven people.

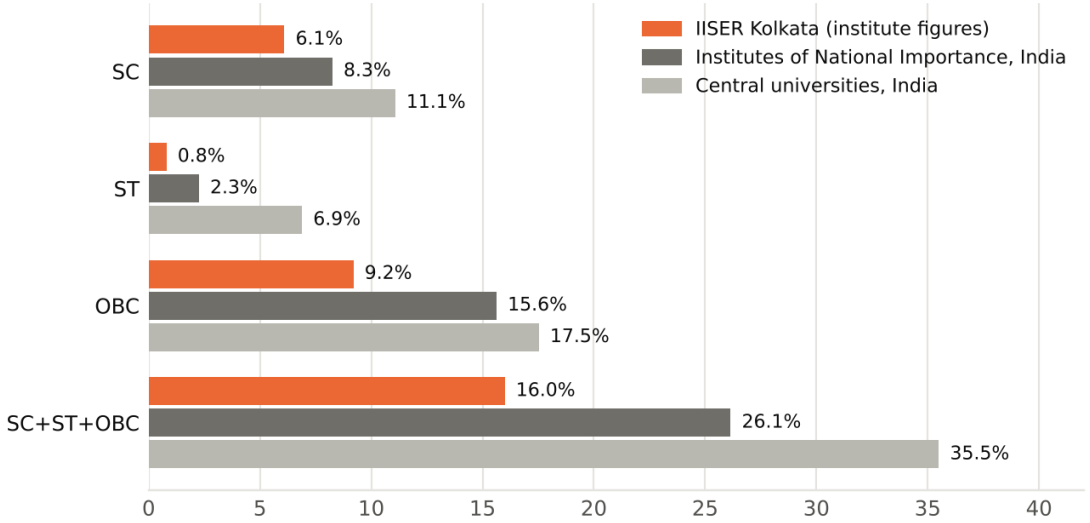


Figure 6: Faculty shares: IISER Kolkata, INIs and central universities. IISER Kolkata: institute figures for 131 faculty, director excluded (2026). INI and central universities: AISHE 2023-24, Table 30.

6. States: why SC faculty look the same everywhere

Across the 32 states and union territories with at least 1,000 teachers, faculty share follows student share closely for ST (slope 0.91) and OBC (0.84) but only loosely for SC (0.43; Figure 7). SC student share ranges from 0.8% to 25.4% across these states, while SC faculty share ranges from 1.3% to 15.3%. Punjab, for example, has 25.4% SC students but 8.5% SC faculty; West Bengal 18.9% and 11.5%; Kerala 6.9% and 4.1%. Outside the north-eastern states, where ST people are the majority, the ST slope falls from 0.91 to 0.43.

The SC pattern is what we would expect if SC faculty numbers depend on something that does not vary much by state (for example, the national pool of SC PhD holders or national recruitment) and less on the local student population. The data cannot test this, so we leave it as a question. States also apply their own rules, and the figures are state averages across very different institutions.

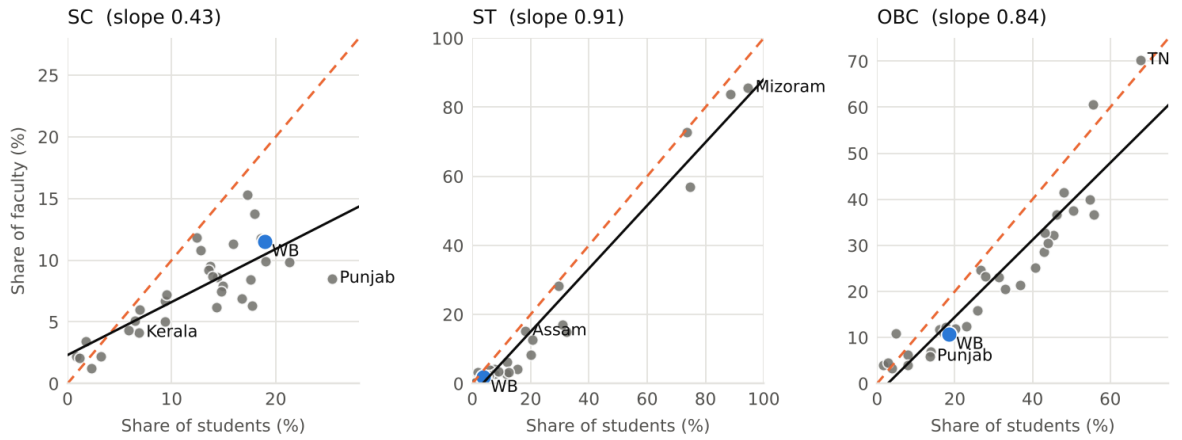


Figure 7: Share of faculty against share of students, by state, 2023-24. Each dot is a state or union territory with at least 1,000 teachers. Black line: fitted line; slope in the panel title. Source: AISHE Tables 14 and 21.

7. Women among SC, ST and OBC faculty

Women are 44.9% of all faculty in 2023-24, up from 42.5% (Figure 8). Among SC faculty the share is 39.7%, lower than any other group, against 46.6% for ST and 44.2% for OBC. This echoes our AISHE student finding that SC women are the thinnest group at PhD level [2]. In INIs, women are 22.1% of faculty and 21.1% of SC faculty (about 409 of 1,935 SC faculty).

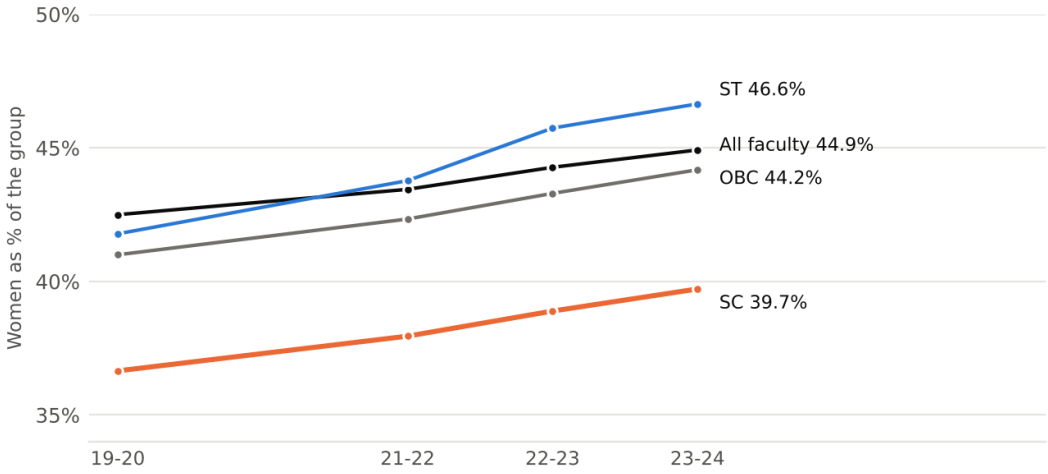


Figure 8: Women as a share of faculty, by social group, India. Source: AISHE Table 21.

Inferences

- **Most of the national loss comes before faculty.** SC and ST shares fall from undergraduate to PhD, and faculty shares then sit near the PhD level. For ST faculty the last step loses more.
- **INIs are the exception, and the gap is not new.** Faculty at INIs are about 20 points below the student share, and that gap has not narrowed in four years because the student share is also rising. IISER Kolkata is below the INI average.

- **New appointments are more diverse than the stock.** This is held nationally and at INIs. It shows the pace of change is small in absolute terms rather than absent: it could take decades at the 2019-2024 pace.
- **SC faculty look much the same in every state.** That points to something other than the local student population, such as the national PhD pool or recruitment. The data cannot test this.

Questions this raises for the people who know the institute

- If the shortfall at INIs is mainly in the national PhD pool, what would change it? If it is in recruitment, what in the process matters?

This is the question that we've tried to answer via our interactions with the institute SC-ST Cell

Methods and limitations in data

- **Near-complete survey, not a sample.** AISHE asks every institution to report; we do not know the response rate by table. Intervals for sampling error are therefore not shown, and a difference of a fraction of a point may reflect reporting.
- **Teachers, not regular faculty.** AISHE counts all teaching staff. The IISER Kolkata figures count regular faculty, so the comparison is approximate.
- **INI is a mixed category.** It includes IITs, NITs, AIIMS, IIMs and the IISERs. AISHE does not separate them. We cannot say how IISERs as a group compare. We could only get the category wise individual faculty count for IISER Kolkata via the DoFA (Dean of Faculty Affairs) Office. We could not get the same data from other institutes.
- **Logistical blind-spots.** Shares are of everyone in post. Net changes between years hide departures and may include institutions that began reporting.
- **Different rules apply by type.** Central institutions follow central lists. States use their own lists and quotas, especially for OBC.
- **State analysis is ecological.** Fits across 32 states describe states, not people or institutes. Slopes use ordinary least squares; intervals come from resampling states 4,000 times.
- **No category by post.** AISHE does not give categories by professor, associate or assistant, so we cannot see whether the shares differ by rank.
- **2020-21 is missing.** We used the four reports we had; changes between 2019-20 and 2021-22 span two years.

Literature

[1] All India Survey on Higher Education (AISHE), Final Reports 2019-20, 2021-22, 2022-23 and 2023-24, Department of Higher Education, Ministry of Education. Tables 11, 14, 21, 27 and 30.

[2] The team's AISHE inclusion study on SC, ST and OBC students and women by level of study (UG, PG, PhD), same source.

[3] Central Educational Institutions (Reservation in Admission) Act, 2006, and the 2019 Act on reservation in teachers' cadre.

Appendices

Appendix A. National teachers by social group and year

Year	Teachers	SC %	ST %	OBC %	SC+ST+OBC %	Women %	SC women %
2019-20	1,503,156	9.0	2.4	32.1	43.5	42.5	36.7
2021-22	1,597,688	9.3	2.6	32.3	44.2	43.4	38.0
2022-23	1,664,172	9.5	2.8	32.5	44.8	44.3	38.9
2023-24	1,732,294	9.6	2.8	32.6	45.1	44.9	39.7

Appendix B. By type of university, 2023-24 (faculty % / student %)

Type	Teachers	SC	ST	OBC	Together	Ratio
Institutes of National Importance	23,440	8.3 / 13.4	2.3 / 6.5	15.6 / 26.4	26.1 / 46.3	0.56
Central universities	16,062	11.1 / 13.2	6.9 / 4.4	17.5 / 18.0	35.5 / 35.6	1.00
State public universities	66,942	11.7 / 14.8	3.2 / 7.2	24.9 / 40.6	39.8 / 62.6	0.64
State private universities	119,573	4.0 / 7.4	1.8 / 4.4	16.7 / 24.6	22.6 / 36.3	0.62
Deemed (private)	63,001	4.6 / 5.6	0.6 / 1.3	34.7 / 34.3	39.9 / 41.2	0.97

Ratio is the combined faculty share divided by the combined student share. Student shares are for enrolment at all levels in university teaching departments (Table 27).

Appendix C. States with at least 10,000 teachers, 2023-24 (faculty % / student %)

State	Teachers	SC	ST	OBC
Tamil Nadu	218,656	11.8 / 18.6	0.3 / 0.9	70.3 / 67.7
Uttar Pradesh	209,212	9.9 / 19.0	0.3 / 1.0	30.5 / 43.9
Maharashtra	186,465	11.8 / 12.4	1.9 / 4.8	23.1 / 31.3
Karnataka	156,162	8.7 / 13.9	2.3 / 5.8	37.6 / 50.4
Andhra Pradesh	108,354	15.3 / 17.3	1.8 / 5.0	36.7 / 46.3
Rajasthan	91,920	8.5 / 17.6	3.3 / 12.5	32.7 / 43.1
Madhya Pradesh	89,840	7.9 / 14.9	2.8 / 11.6	25.1 / 40.7
Telangana	84,568	11.3 / 15.9	3.5 / 8.9	41.5 / 48.0
West Bengal	78,203	11.5 / 18.9	1.8 / 3.8	10.7 / 18.5
Gujarat	69,247	7.2 / 9.5	6.2 / 12.0	20.5 / 32.9
Kerala	67,723	4.1 / 6.9	0.3 / 1.1	39.9 / 54.8
Punjab	51,839	8.5 / 25.4	0.2 / 0.6	5.9 / 13.5
Odisha	49,361	6.3 / 17.8	4.1 / 15.4	15.9 / 25.8
Bihar	45,154	6.2 / 14.3	0.7 / 1.8	36.6 / 55.8
Haryana	44,928	6.9 / 16.7	0.1 / 0.6	12.4 / 23.0
Assam	28,083	6.7 / 9.3	15.2 / 18.1	24.6 / 26.6
Chhattisgarh	25,999	9.5 / 13.7	8.4 / 20.1	32.2 / 45.4

State	Teachers	SC	ST	OBC
Delhi	24,377	9.2 / 13.6	3.2 / 1.7	11.7 / 16.0
Uttarakhand	20,064	7.5 / 14.7	1.2 / 2.9	12.0 / 20.1
Jharkhand	18,180	5.0 / 9.4	12.8 / 20.6	28.6 / 43.0
Jammu and Kashmir	12,016	5.1 / 6.4	2.7 / 7.5	3.9 / 7.9
Himachal Pradesh	11,347	9.9 / 21.3	3.9 / 5.8	6.9 / 13.8